

Double TAKE

It's sequel season again, as Uttar Pradesh's re-anointed power couple returns to the spotlight, playing saviour to a desperate Congress

■ By Priya Sahgal

They're back, the socialist and the socialite. It's been a rather busy week for Messrs Mulayam Singh Yadav and Amar Singh as they rush from 7 Race Course Road to 10 Janpath, from press conferences to newspaper headlines. After a long spell of oblivion, both are revelling in the limelight and the corridors of power. A man known to keep a ledger book of grudges, Amar Singh must be particularly pleased at the turn of events. It has been four years since he was unceremoniously thrown out of 10 Janpath. On July 4, not only did he get an appointment but he even got to sit expansively on the beige sofa upholstered with handloom fabric, in Sonia Gandhi's study, making small talk with the former object of his attrition, seated on his right. "Rivals are not enemies," he later told the media.

Both Mulayam and Amar Singh know that their time, however short-lived, has finally come. Despite being

the fourth largest party (including the BJP) in the 2004 polls with 39 MPs, the Samajwadi Party (SP) had been denied the spoils of power by none other than Sonia who had not forgotten Mulayam's 1999 slight when he refused to support her bid for power. But now, nearly a decade later, Sonia once again needs Mulayam's MPs to keep her government in office. As for the SP, weakened in Uttar Pradesh, with Mulayam ousted from chief minister-ship in the 2007 state elections, and consistently ignored by the media, the re-anointed power duo is only too willing to be wooed by the Congress. For a price, of course.

Despite all the grand talk of national interest, it is personal interest alone that is driving the deal behind the deal. In exchange for support at the Centre, the SP, which has 97 MLAs in Uttar Pradesh, wants a tie-up in the state. Mayawati with her 206 MLAs is on an upswing and the duo needs Congress support to check her rampage. Just two months ago, she won all the five seats in a state by-poll, even though the entire Opposition was united against her. An alliance, even if it gives SP the lion's share, suits the Congress. With only 21 MLAs, it has a limited stake in the state. For SP, though, it means everything. Ever since he lost the elections in Uttar Pradesh, Mulayam has been hounded by Mayawati. She has rolled back most of the favours granted to his rich industrialist friends. Pending CBI cases and an unsympathetic government at the Centre have only added to his woes. In

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NETWORK NETAS: Amar Singh shares centrestage with Mulayam



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